



Eric Gordon Stearns

1895 – 1915

Civilian Resaerch

Field Name	Field Data	Source of data
Casualty Name	Eric Gordon Stearns	CWGC
Date of Birth	25/3/1895 Born in Hornsey	See baptism entry below which includes birth date There are discrepancies re his date of birth but the baptism entry clearly says born 25/3/1895 so we are accepting that date. 1901 census
Date of Death (from Spreadsheet)	20	CWGC
Age at death (from Spreadsheet)	6/8/1915	CWGC
Marital Status	Not to my knowledge & this ref	https://ww1photos.com/firstworldwarsoldiers/index.php/2023/07/11/stearns-e-g-2nd-lt-4th-royal-fusiliers/

Children (if any)	ditto	
Occupation prior to Call up	In the 1911 census he was still at school aged 16. Sun Insurance Office probably.	1911 census Lyonian magazine 1912 https://ww1photos.com/firstworldwarsoldiers/index.php/2023/07/11/stearns-e-g-2nd-lt-4th-royal-fusiliers/
Parents	Thomas Robert Stearns and Mrs Alice Stearns of Lansdowne, Woodridings, Hatch End	CWGC, 1911 census
Listed Address(s)	Besides the address on the CWGC the family also lived at 16 Adolphus Road, Stoke Newington in 1901	CWGC 1901 census
Parents /Fathers occupation	Insurance official. The Lyonian article you mentioned says they expect to see Eric at the Sun Insurance Office. I wonder if that's where both his father and brother worked?	1911 census and Lyonian magazine 1912
Brothers and Sisters	Hubert Grant Stearns, organist at St Georges Headstone and in the 1911 census an insurance clerk. NB: one of the newspaper reports says Herbert but the census says Hubert	Uxbridge & W Drayton Gazette see below and 1911 census
Years at John Lyon School		
Other schools	St Johns College	See below
Obituary		
Additional sources of data		
War Memorials:	Pinner war memorial Transcript of memorial	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/11095 http://west-middlesex-fhs.org.uk/WMLinks/PinnerWM.pdf
	John Lyon School memorial	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/341001

	Sun Insurance Roll of Honour. Located at the National Memorial Arboratum	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/2106636
	St Mary's Church, Church Hill, Harrow on the Hill	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/340901
	St Anselms Church, Hatch End	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/831703
	St John's College memorial next to Stoke Newington Town Hall, Stoke Newington Library, Stoke Newington Church Street as E Stearns	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/11945

Military Research

JLS WWI RoH	STEARNS E.G.
CWGC Reference	https://www.cwgc.org/find-war-dead/casualty/149593/stearns,-eric-gordon/
Age	20
DoD	06-Aug-15
Rank	Lt
Regiment	Royal Fusiliers 4th Bn
	<u>LIJSENTHOEK MILITARY CEMETERY</u>
Location	West-Vlaanderen, Belgium
CWGC in process of uploading image of headstones which will give us his age, hopefully.	Son of Thos. R. Stearns, of Lansdowne, Woodridings, Hatch End, Middlesex Lieutenant Eric Gordon Stearns died on August 6, 1915, at the young age of 20. He served with the 4th Battalion of the Royal Fusiliers (City of London Regiment). Lieutenant Stearns died at Abeele, Belgium, a village located west of Ypres right along the French-Belgian border. He is buried at the Commonwealth War Graves Commission (CWGC) Loker Churchyard in West-Vlaanderen, Belgium (Grave Reference: II. C. 20.). He died of wounds received in action in Belgium. While serving in the Ypres sector, Lieutenant Stearns was in charge of an engineering and infantry party tasked with digging a new frontline trench under the cover of darkness. Frontline digging parties were incredibly hazardous roles, exposed to sudden enemy flare lights, targeted machine-gun sweeps, and pre-ranged sniper fire. During the operation, his party was caught in an exchange, and Stearns was severely wounded. He was evacuated behind the immediate lines to a medical post or field ambulance in the Abeele sector, where he succumbed to his injuries. Historical logs and letters from his commanding officer, Lieut.-Col. W. F. Sweny, and his men note that Stearns was highly regarded as an exceptionally cool, fearless leader who was "almost worshipped by the men under his command" for always keeping a cheery word for everyone despite the intense conditions

Story of Sacrifice

Eric Gordon Stearns (1895 – 1915)



Civilian Life

Eric Stearns was born in Hornsey on 25 March 1895, the son of Thomas Stearns, an insurance official, and Alice Stearns. The family later lived at Lansdowne, Woodridings, Hatch End. Eric was educated at St John's College and the Lower School of John Lyon, where he became a member of the football 1st XI and later a school monitor. The Lyonian magazine of 1912 remembered him with a warm, perhaps a little tongue in cheek testimonial, when he left school. "Of all the boys who left their old School at Christmas, we want to say a few words of kindly farewell. Eric Stearns, who was a Lyonian almost from babyhood—at least, he was wonderfully small when first I saw him—has left as Monitor, member of Football 1st XI., and Six-footer. Besides that, we are in hopes that he has added the London Matriculation to his list of honours. E. S. was a really capital actor, and, alongside his bosom friend, Leo Parsons, made no small stir when he first appeared in "Twelfth Night." Into the bargain, he was always a rare good Lyonian, with an unmistakable touch of the public school boy about him, and that is no bad thing. "

Stearns subsequently worked as a clerk at the Sun Insurance Office.

Military Life

Stearns had joined the Artists' Rifles in 1912 and volunteered for foreign service when war broke out. He received his commission as a Second Lieutenant on 6 April 1915 and was posted to the 4th Battalion, Royal Fusiliers.

While serving in the Ypres sector, Lieutenant Stearns was in charge of an engineering and infantry party tasked with digging a new frontline trench under the cover of darkness. Frontline digging parties were incredibly hazardous roles, exposed to sudden enemy flare lights, targeted machine-gun sweeps, and pre-ranged sniper fire. During the operation, his party was caught in an exchange, and Stearns was severely wounded. The contemporary account records that a bullet struck him above the hip and passed upwards. His men attempted to help him, but their efforts were unsuccessful, and he was taken by motor ambulance to a casualty station at Abeele. He died from his wounds on 6 August 1915, aged 20.

After his death, tributes came from officers and men who had served with him. His commanding officer, Lieutenant-Colonel W. F. Sweny, wrote "I have seen enough of your son to realise what a useful and cool officer he was"; Sergt. F. H. Smith: "Mr. Stearns was almost worshipped by the men under his command; they would have followed him anywhere, for they knew he was a man. He had not an atom of fear in him, and he always had a smile and a cheery word for everybody. I do not think anybody could be more liked and respected than he was." Private W. H. Leighton described how Stearns bore his wound and said that he had been a brave officer in whom the men had the greatest confidence. A further letter from his company commander described his death as a personal sorrow, while the Forces Chaplain told Stearns's parents that their son had been "highly thought of by his senior officers" and that his men spoke of his "courage and coolness in the hour of danger." The chaplain added that his men "would have done anything for him" and deeply felt his loss.

Eric Gordon Stearns was subsequently commemorated at St Anselm's Church, Hatch End, and his name was recorded on a number of war memorials, including those connected with his school and the Sun Insurance Office.

To read testimonials from Eric's school pals in life and his comrades' testimonials in death, and when looking at the photos of him from boyhood through to manhood, it is easy to appreciate that he was a young man with a promising future, who's life, like so many, was cut tragically short.

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Photos



Stearns 1909 Football



1910/1911 football



1914/15



1909 1st XI Football



1910 / 11 1st XI Football

Notes and Clippings

Entry in Lyonian Magazine 1912

Of all the boys who left their old School at Christmas, we want to say a few words of kindly farewell. Eric Stearns, who was a Lyonian almost from babyhood—at least, he was wonderfully small when first I saw him—has left as Monitor, member of Football 1st XI., and Six-footer. Besides that, we are in hopes that he has added the London Matriculation to his list of honours. E. S. was a really capital actor, and, alongside his bosom friend, Leo Parsons, made no small stir when he first appeared in "Twelfth Night." Into the

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Baptism entry including birth date

No. 728	William	Caroline	(Born 24 15/55)	Frederick		(Vicar)
18 75	Eric	Thomas				
april	forden	Robert	Stearns	49 Queen	Clerk	John
14 th		Alice	(Born March 25/55)	Road		McGowan
No. 729						(Vicar)
18 75	William					

Uxbridge__W_Drayton_Gazette_27_August_1915

—O—
We regret to announce that Second Lieut. Eric Stearns, brother of Mr. Herbert Stearns, organist at St. George's Church, Headstone, has died of wounds in France. He was very popular in his regiment, the 4th Battalion Royal Fusiliers, and his many friends will receive the news with great regret.
—O—

[Uxbridge_W_Drayton_Gazette_27_August_1915](#)

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LIEUT. ERIC STEARNS.

The Chaplain of the forces, writing to the parents, says:— "I feel I must write to you to express my deep sympathy with you in your great sorrow. Your son was killed on the night of the 15th October. He was in command of a party working at the Front, and was struck by a piece of shell. His death was instantaneous, so that he did not suffer. I buried him on Saturday night in the cemetery near here, and a cross is being erected to his memory. It may comfort you to know that he was a good soldier, and was highly thought of by his senior officers. His men would have done anything for him, and speak of his courage and coolness in the hour of danger. They all feel his loss deeply."

From: <https://ww1photos.com/firstworldwarsoldiers/index.php/2023/07/11/stearns-e-g-2nd-lt-4th-royal-fusiliers/>

Stearns E G 2nd Lt 4th Royal Fusiliers

Posted on 11 July 2023 by WW1 Photos



Stearns E G 2nd Lt 4th
Royal Fusiliers



From same:

STEARNS, ERIC GORDON, 2nd Lieut., 4th Battn. Royal Fusiliers, yr. s. of Thomas Robert Stearns, of Lansdowne, Woodridings, Hatch End, co. Middlesex, Insurance Official, by his wife, Alice, dau. of James Grant, of Ipswich and Belize; b. Hornsey, 25 March, 1895; educ. St. John's College, and Lower School, Harrow was a Clerk in the Sun Insurance Office; joined the Artists' Rifles (28th London Regt.) in 1912; volunteered for foreign service on the outbreak of war; was given a commission as 2nd Lieut. 6 April, 1915, and posted to the Royal Fusiliers; went to France in Oct. 1914, and died at Abeele of wounds received in action in Belgium, while in charge of a party digging a new trench; unm. His commanding officer, Lieut.-Col. W. F. Sweny, wrote: "I have seen enough of your son to realise what a useful and cool officer he was "; Sergt. F. H. Smith: "Mr. Stearns was almost worshipped by the men under his command; they would have followed him anywhere, for they knew he was a man. He had not an atom of fear in him, and he had always a smile and a cheery word for everybody. I do not think anybody could be more liked and respected than he was and Private W. H. Leighton: "The bullet caught him just above the hip and passed upwards. We did everything we possibly could but all in vain, worse luck. He bore it extremely well, as he always did everything, being a very brave officer and one whom the men had the greatest confidence in and would have followed him anywhere." Source : De Ruvigny's Roll Of Honour Vol 1	STEARNS, ERIC GORDON, 2nd Lieut., 4th Battn. Royal Fusiliers, yr. s. of Thomas Robert Stearns, of Lansdowne, Woodridings, Hatch End, co. Middlesex, Insurance Official, by his wife, Alice, dau. of James Grant, of Ipswich and Belize; b. Hornsey, 25 March, 1895; educ. St. John's College, and Lower School, Harrow; was a Clerk in the Sun Insurance Office; joined the Artists' Rifles (28th London Regt.) in 1912; volunteered for foreign service on the outbreak of war; was given a commission as 2nd Lieut. 6 April, 1915, and posted to the Royal Fusiliers; went to France in Oct. 1914, and died at Abeele of wounds received in action in Belgium, while in charge of a party digging a new trench; unm. His commanding officer, Lieut.-Col. W. F. Sweny, wrote: "I have seen enough of your son to realise what a useful and cool officer he was"; Sergt. F. H. Smith: "Mr. Stearns was almost worshipped by the men under his command; they would have followed him anywhere, for they knew he was a man. He had not an atom of fear in him, and he had always a smile and a cheery word for everybody. I do not think anybody could be more liked and respected than he was and Private W. H. Leighton: "The bullet caught him just above the hip and passed upwards. We did everything we possibly could but all in vain, worse luck. He bore it extremely well, as he always did everything, being a very brave officer and one whom the men had the greatest confidence in and would have followed him anywhere." Source: De Ruvigny's Roll Of Honour Vol 1
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This is the link to De Rubigny's Roll of Honour Vol 1.

<https://search.findmypast.co.uk/record?id=GBM%2FDR%2FVOL1A%2F0341&parentid=GBM%2FDR2%2F005782>

from a in- d and did he is had s, but offers ferent. Dr. Mrs. laddi- wel- se pa- come s, per ican wards at the arrow health of the ot he a that dished in the to the of in- r, Dr. Mrs. re the he did tarted n and That arting nether such was if it n that n that to see ned to re for id not iscour- selves re, the Coun- could Local led the r Me- id that nd the made Weald al. The as com- il Har- morial at the s Baby ally, to ck and een a happen ould be se good afford d, and verlook id sup- ded to ion be C

full naval honours.

REQUIEM AT ST. ANSELM'S.
COMMEMORATION SERVICE.

In accordance with the wish of the Archbishops of Canterbury and York, the last Sunday in the year was set apart for commemoration of the brave souls who, during the great European War, have given their lives for King and country. The services at St. Anselm's, Hatch End, began with a celebration of the Eucharist at 8. This service partook of a commemorative character, with special collect, Epistle and Gospel. Communion was given to a number of communicants who had responded to the invitation to plead the cause of our departed heroes. The principal service for the day was the Solemn Requiem sung at 11. Punctually at the appointed hour the celebrant in alb and stole took his place at the High Altar with two attendant servers. After the celebrant had been vested with the chasuble the service opened with the Introit psalm, "Lord, thou hast been our refuge." Then came the ninefold Kyrie, the specially appointed collect, Epistle, and Gospel following in due order. The Nicene Creed was then intoned, the sermon coming in its place as laid down in the rubric.

The Vicar, the Rev. F. A. J. Bealey, preached, taking as his text a prayer of sublime beauty from an ancient Liturgy "Come, O Thou the Sanctifier, Almighty and Everlasting God, and bless this Sacrifice prepared for Thy Holy Name." In a discourse delivered with all the impressiveness the occasion demanded the preacher reminded his hearers that our holy faith was founded on sacrifice and that the fulness of the Catholic life could only be reached through sacrifice. He referred to those who from that parish had made the supreme sacrifice and that we were engaged in an act of divine charity on their behalf. "In the sight of the universe they seemed to die and their departure is taken for misery and their going from us to be utter destruction; but they are at peace."

After the sermon the service proceeded on its usual course, the solemn moment of consecration being duly notified by the triple notes of the consecration bell. Before the service closed, the hymn, "Brother, now thy toils are o'er" was sung kneeling with great devotion. As the choir left the Church Bishop How's fine hymn "For all Thy Saints" was sung to a majestic tune taken from the English Hymnal. Evening devotions were sung at 6.30 and consisted of special psalms and prayers recited from the Altar. The latter half of Evensong followed, the sermon being preached by the Rev. R. B. Armstrong. The alma throughout the day were given to the St. Anselm's War Memorial Fund.

The names of the fallen heroes who were commemorated from the Altar by name are: Harry Hodgins, Noel Atkinson, Edward Hol- derness, Eric Stearns, Leslie Jacobs, Jack Gill, Charles Hill, Gilbert Woodcock, John Aldridge, Michael Hill, Evers Leggett, Musgrave Webb, Charles Humphries, James Stevens, John Mad- dock, Fred King Arthur Hermon, Harold Gordon, Donald Hutchison, John Stanforth, George Brown, Fred Atkinson, Joseph Sower- by, Albert Sugars, and Horace Crane.

Mr. C. M. Mayson, deputy-organist, very efficiently presided at the organ. The ladies' choir gave useful help which it has done throughout the war period.

COUNTY WAR MEMORIAL.—Colonel C. W.

HARROW OBSERVER - 03 JANUARY 1919

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From the Centenary issue of the Lyonian,
Researched by pupils 2014

From the Centenary issue of the Lyonian, Researched by pupils 2014



Birth date is incorrect

Researched by pupils 2014

Stearns, E G

Eric Gordon Stearns was the son of Thomas Robert Stearns and was born on 23th May 1895. He joined the London Regiment. Died from a wound, received while in charge of a digging party, digging a new trench. He was shot in the side and was killed from peritonitis. He was a cheerful and fearless man, and was praised by all his comrades.

He was out digging at the front line during the night, a lot of bullets were being shot by the enemy and unfortunately one bullet hit him in the side and was immediately carried out by a motor ambulance to Aberle casualty station where the following night he died.

[Birth date is incorrect]

Report from Hornsey & Finsbury Park Journal 27/7/1901. St John's College athletics

ST. JOHN'S COLLEGE ATHLETIC SPORTS.

The tenth annual athletic sports in connection with St. John's College (Greenlanes) were held on Wednesday afternoon at the Tufnell Park Athletic Grounds, Boston Avenue, before a large attendance of spectators. Magnificent weather smiled on the day, everything passing off well, and all concerned are to be congratulated. The following were the officials: — President, Mr. J. S. Coombes, M.A. (the Principal); committee, the Masters; judges, Messrs. J. B. Lee, A. Boley, F. Frankford; starter, referee, Messrs. F. T. Smith and H. G. B. Brewer; handicapper, Mr. E. R. Phelp; timekeeper, Messrs. Taylor and Davis. During the intervals the International Military Band, conducted by Louis Seidel, discoursed sweet music. The programme consisted of 23 events, some of which, perhaps, caused more excitement than the father's 300 yards scratch race, in which there can, and Mr. W. Bates cannot, compete now; nor is it easy to run that Old Boys 440 yards scratch, won by C. S. Wright, the winner accomplishing a fine performance, covering it in 55 secs. The following were the results: —

High jump. — W. A. Cumming, 4ft. 8in., 1.

200 yards handicap. — Class IV.: J. W. Barrett, 1; B. G. Green, 2. Time, 20 4-5th sec.

100 yards handicap. — Class II.: A. E. Green, 1; A. Taylor, 2. Time, 12 3-5th sec.

220 yards handicap. — Class I.: W. A. Cumming, 1; O. G. Saddington, 2. Time, 27 4-5th sec.

440 yards handicap. — Class I.: W. A. Cumming, 1; O. G. Saddington, 2. Time, 62 secs.

Dribbling football. — Class III.: E. A. Saddington, 1. Class II.: A. King, 1. Class I.: T. Lee, 1; A. C. A. Moss, 2.

100 yards scratch race. — Class III.: E. G. Saddington, 1; W. Felton, 2. 18 sec. Class II.: E. F. Clarke, 1; L. Taylor, 2. 12 sec. Class I.: W. E. Carpenter, 1; G. Carpenter, 2. 11 3-5th sec.

One mile bicycle handicap. — S. M. Lions, scratch, 1. 2min. 55sec.

440 yards handicap. — Class IV.: H. F. Clarke, 1; E. Watkins, 2. 80 sec. Class III.: A. De Lenow, 1; H. Carpenter, 2. 75 4-5 sec. Class I.: G. Carpenter, 1; A. Bridge, 2. 60 sec.

One mile handicap. — G. Carpenter, scratch, 1; A. Bridge, 2; E. Starling, 3. 5 min. 10 sec.

Obstacle race. — P. Todd, 1; H. Walford, 2.

Slow bicycle race. — J. Howell, 1.

600 yards hurdle handicap. — H. Stead, 1. 66 sec.

Sack race. — H. Tame, 1; F. Rainford, 2.

One mile walking handicap. — G. Willmott, 1; E. Smalley, 2; F. Todd, 3. 8 min. 41 sec.

Consolation. — (E. G. Evans), 1; C. G. Mitchell, 2; E. Crouch, 3.

Fathers' race, 300. — H. G. Baten, 1. 52 sec. All ran well.

Old Boys' 440 yards scratch race. — C. S. Wright, 1; H. Lines, 2. Time, 55 1-5 sec.

Old Boys' Hurdle scratch race, 120 yards. — W. H. Lovibond, 1. Time 21 sec.

Tug-of-war. — Class III. vs. Class I. and II.: Team (F. G. Duns), 1; Class I. vs. II.: Team (W. E. Carpenter), 1.

At the conclusion of the sports the prizes were distributed by Mrs. J. S. Smith, Mayoress of Finsbury, in the centre of the enclosure. On Mrs. Smith ascending the platform, a band played a march, and at the end her daughter, Miss Gladys, was presented with a beautiful bouquet. Prizes not contested by local tradesmen were given by Messrs. O. Brown, Green-lanes; and G. A. Sparks. General champions were: Class I.: W. A. Cumming, to whom Mr. E. H. Phelp's cup for the best timing goes; Class II.: L. Taylor; and tie held in Class III. between E. A. Saddington and E. G. Saddington. Mr. Mortlock proposed three cheers for Mrs. Smith, the judges, the band, the sports, and others present, and the proceedings terminated after cheers for the headmaster.

Master Philip Saddington, one of the...

